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CENTERPIECE

Charles club commemorates first radio transmission 125 years ago

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Bill Luyster, an amateur radio operator, uses a digital radio model on Dec. 23 to contact people from around the first voice transmission over the radio by Reginald Fessenden on Cobb Island.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

“C-Q, C-Q, C-Q November 3 Victor, November 3 Victor Special Events station from Cobb Island, Maryland. C-Q, C-Q, C-Q this is November 3 Victor.”

Sounds of digital communications and trying to make contact with other amateur radio operators could be heard around Cobb Island last week on Dec. 23 during a special event.

Members of the Charles County Amateur Radio Club met at Very House and Fisherman’s Field on Cobb Island to commemorate the first transmission radio 125 years ago when Reginald Fessenden had the idea to put human voice on the air instead of using Morse code.

The spark gap transmitter used by Fessenden had a morse transmitter so they could hear the dots and dashes, Jeff Humbert, member of the Charles County Amateur Radio Club, said.

“Voice was a big step to be able to transfer your voice,” he said. “He lived to see the radio broadcast of the 1930s.”

On Dec. 23, 1900, Fessenden’s message was “One, two, three, four. Is it snowing where you are, Mr. Thiessen?”

Thiessen responded, “Yes.”

Fessenden spent a few years on Cobb Island with his associates and built “all sorts of various contraptions” until they succeeded, Bob Curran, president of the Charles County Amateur Radio Club, told Southern Maryland News.

“No one could even talk on the radio until he figured out how to do it,” he said. “It happened in our backyard.”

Last week, Curran set up a TV transmitter to send video from Very House to Fisherman's Field while digital communications, the same way a cellphone "talks" to a cellphone tower, came from a digital radio model.

On the digital radio model at the Very House, Bill Luyster, a member of the Charles County Amateur Radio Club, made contact with two amateur radio operators the morning of the event. Then around 11 a.m., his computer lit up red, signifying operators were making contact with him.

One of the callers was from Italy. Another was from Russia or Ukraine and two were from somewhere in the United States, according to the local club members.

With a few clicks of his mouse, Luyster received the caller's identification, the signal report and maidenhead grid square, which is the location on a grid square map.

"This transmission that's going out digitally is almost all [automatic]," he said.

A yellow bar on the computer is the transmitter Luyster uses to contact potential callers and green is when operators call "C-Q," which is when they call any station that is on the same frequency and sending digital signals.

The club has a QSL card, like a postcard that commemorates events, that callers receive that include information about the radio transmission that can be used to help them get amateur radio awards, Jeff Humbert said. It used to be the only way to send information, but now it can be sent through a computer.

During Fessenden's time, there were only two houses nearby, Pam Humbert, member of the Charles County Amateur Radio Club, said.

Fessenden got supplies from Washington, D.C. It was easily accessible, but still isolated.

“At the time [it] was new technology,” Pam Humbert said. “He wanted to keep it secret for a while.”

Fessenden made it possible for amateur radio operators to participate in the club’s events like “Parks on the Air,” which makes radio contacts from different state national parks, or operate their own stations at home.

“These are the kind of things amateurs do to occupy their time,” Luyster said. “It’s just a hobby.”

In the words of an amateur radio operator: “7-3.”

Or in plain language: “thank you, good bye.”



Making contact

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